



**HINA NAGARAJAN**  
59, MD & CEO, Diageo India

## LET THE GOOD TIMES ROLL

**SINCE HINA NAGARAJAN** took charge of Diageo India in the middle of the pandemic, the company's performance has improved steadily, shrugging off challenges from multiple fronts. As the seasoned executive steered the ship towards premiumisation through an agile growth strategy, the company finally managed to distribute dividends to its stakeholders in FY24 for the first time since the acquisition of its flagship Indian entity, United Spirits Ltd (USL), in FY14. Last year, Diageo's standalone net sales

surged 10.5% year-on-year to ₹10,692 crore, backed by its premium segment, which now forms 87% of its portfolio. With such a record, it's no wonder that she is on the *BT* MPW list. "As a leader, I have two priorities: delivering sustained long-term growth and profitability for the company while empowering our teams to build an organisation of the future. Since I took charge as the MD & CEO, we are strategically focussed on premiumisation," she tells *BT*, adding that this has resulted in acceleration of growth and profitability. Nagarajan says that over the next five years, with 100 million new consumers, India will have 25% of all new alco-beverage consumers in the world. The good times look set to keep flowing. **BT**

— BY ARNAB DUTTA

### ADVICE TO YOUR YOUNGER SELF

Just believe in yourself and the impact you can make

### MANTRA TO NAVIGATE CHALLENGES

Adapt, innovate and collaborate

## QUENCHING THE THIRST

### FOR JAYANTI KHAN

Chauhan, owning a legacy brand like Bisleri offers a huge opportunity; however, it is crucial to proceed with caution. After all, the brand's name is synonymous with the category, which is an advantage. She says the brand has consistently engaged with

operates in the hydration space, and Chauhan is clear that the goal "is to own the narrative in the country".

Cutting her teeth in the business proved beneficial, and she reminisces about her early days on the factory floor, where she grasped the intricacies of

### ADVICE TO YOUR YOUNGER SELF

The most powerful person in a room is the one who decides that their self-worth is not a group decision

### MANTRA TO NAVIGATE CHALLENGES

Rely on instincts and be guided by common sense

every generation since its inception. "To sustain our legacy, we have developed a two-pronged strategy focussed on leveraging insights and initiating actions that resonate with the youth." Bisleri

manufacturing. Although she finds the overall business exciting, her affection for Vedica is evident. "Its transformation into a premium Himalayan spring water brand was significant," she recalls.

## THE RETAIL DISRUPTOR

**IN INDIA'S RETAIL sector today, scale is a strategic advantage; however, expanding from a large base is difficult. Isha Ambani is cognisant of this and has shown a compelling blend of growth and necessary aggression. Her leadership helped**

### ISHA AMBANI

32, Director, RIL, Reliance Retail & Reliance Jio Infocomm

PHOTO BY MILIND SHELTE